黄石公园狼影再现

Shadows of Wolves Over Yellowstone



狼回来了，河谷恢复就都该归功于狼吗？

英文原文

Yellowstone's **iconic** grey wolves had been **exterminated** by 1926. On 12 January 1995 eight wolves **captured** in Alberta, Canada, were **hauled** to the park in **crates**; six more followed. Released from **enclosures** in late March, they **roamed** the **wilderness**.

In February 2014 a **viral video narrated by** writer George Monbiot **spun** a **compelling narrative**: elk, thinned by wolves and **wary of** them, **retreated from** valleys, letting **willows flourish** and riverbanks **stabilise**. Ecologists call this a **trophic cascade**: **predators** eat or **deter** plant-eaters, and **vegetation rebounds**.

Yet the **census undermined** the thinning claim: elk on the park's northern range **peaked at** about 19,000 in January 1994 and were **dwindling** before wolves arrived, **depleted** by **hunters**, **drought**, and bears. Fear looked weak too: in June 2013 Arthur Middleton's University of Wyoming team found that **collared** elk east of the park kept **grazing** unless wolves **ventured** within half a mile.

Trees **fared no better**: in November 2021 Utah State University's Elaine Brice showed that **sampling** only the tallest **aspens overstated regrowth** four- to sevenfold. The deeper **flaw** was water. Colorado State University's Tom Hobbs and David Cooper had **excluded** elk with fences and built **artificial** beaver **dams**. In January 2024 they reported: **eroding** streams had cut so deep that **stunted** willows no longer reached water.

In January 2025 Oregon State University's William Ripple, an **advocate** of the **hypothesis**, reported one of the world's strongest cascades; critics **disputed** his methods. The question is **unresolved**, but the wolves' shadow looks **fainter** than the **fable** suggested, and the science **messier**. A **discipline** willing to **revise** its **cherished** example may deserve more trust than the fable ever did.

中文译文

黄石公园那些标志性的灰狼，到1926年已遭赶尽杀绝。1995年1月12日，八只在加拿大艾伯塔省捕获的狼装在板条箱里，一路拖运进了公园；随后又来了六只。3月下旬，它们被放出围栏，得以在荒野中四处游荡。

2014年2月，一段火了的视频，由作家乔治·蒙比奥特解说，编织出一个引人入胜的故事。片中说，麋鹿被狼捕杀得数量变少，又处处提防着狼，便撤离了河谷，这让柳树繁茂起来，河岸也稳固下来。生态学家把这称为营养级联：捕食者吃掉或吓阻食草动物，然后植被得以恢复生长。

然而，普查结果首先就动摇了鹿被狼吃少了这一说法。黄石北部草场的麋鹿在1994年1月达到约19,000头的峰值，狼还没来就已日渐减少；鹿群被猎人、干旱和熊不断地消耗着。恐惧一说看来也站不住。2013年6月，阿瑟·米德尔顿领导的怀俄明大学团队发现，园区东侧戴项圈的麋鹿照样吃草，除非狼胆敢踏入进半英里以内。

树木方面的证据也好不到哪里去：2021年11月，犹他州立大学的伊莱恩·布赖斯指出，只抽样测量最高的山杨，会把它们的再生程度夸大四到七倍。更根本的缺陷出在水上。科罗拉多州立大学的汤姆·霍布斯和戴维·库珀用围栏把麋鹿挡在外面，并修建人工海狸坝。2024年1月，他们报告说，不断冲蚀河床的溪流下切太深，那些矮小的柳树已经够不着水了。

2025年1月，这一假说的倡导者、俄勒冈州立大学的威廉·里普尔发文称，黄石的级联效应位居世界最强之列；批评者则对他的方法提出质疑。问题仍悬而未决，但狼投下的影子比谣传所暗示的更加无力，相关研究也要复杂纠结得多。一门学科如果愿意去修正（甚至推翻）自己最珍视的完美案例，那么这门学科，比那个完美的谣传本身更值得信任。

词汇与表达

iconic adj.
标志性的
Yellowstone's iconic grey wolves

exterminated v.
赶尽杀绝
had been exterminated by 1926

captured v.
捕获

hauled v.
拖运

crates n.
板条箱

enclosures n.
围栏
Released from enclosures

roamed v.
四处游荡

wilderness n.
荒野
they roamed the wilderness

viral video adj.
火了的视频

narrated by v.
由……解说

spun v.
编织

compelling adj.
引人入胜的
a compelling narrative

narrative n.
故事
a compelling narrative

wary of adj.
提防
wary of them

retreated from v.
撤离了

willows n.
柳树

flourish v.
繁茂

stabilise v.
稳固

trophic cascade n.
营养级联
a trophic cascade

predators n.
捕食者
predators eat or deter plant-eaters

deter v.
吓阻
deter plant-eaters

vegetation n.
植被
vegetation rebounds

rebounds v.
恢复生长

census n.
普查
the census

undermined v.
动摇了
undermined the thinning claim

peaked at v.
达到……的峰值

词汇与表达（续）

dwindling v.
日渐减少
dwindling before wolves arrived

depleted v.
消耗
depleted by hunters

hunters n.
猎人

drought n.
干旱

collared v.
戴项圈的

grazing v.
吃草

ventured v.
胆敢踏入

fared no better v.
好不到哪里去

sampling n.
抽样测量
sampling only the tallest aspens

aspens n.
山杨

overstated v.
把……夸大
overstated regrowth four- to sevenfold

regrowth n.
再生
overstated regrowth four- to sevenfold

flaw n.
缺陷

excluded v.
把……挡在外面

artificial adj.
人工

dams n.
坝

eroding v.
不断冲蚀

stunted adj.
矮小的

advocate n.
倡导者

hypothesis n.
假说
an advocate of the hypothesis

disputed v.
对……质疑
critics disputed his methods

unresolved adj.
悬而未决
The question is unresolved

fainter adj.
更加无力

fable n.
谣传

messier adj.
复杂纠结

discipline n.
学科

revise v.
修正
revise its cherished example

cherished adj.
珍视的

文章简述

- 回归：1995年，灰狼被重新引入黄石公园。流行故事说：狼吃鹿、鹿怕狼，树木少受啃食就恢复，连河岸也变稳固。
- 疑问：实际调查发现，狼回来之前，北部鹿群已经在下降，猎捕、干旱和熊也有作用；鹿变少不能全算在狼头上。
- 证据：园区东侧被追踪的麋鹿，只有狼进入约半英里内才停止照常吃草。只测长得最高的山杨，还会把恢复程度夸大。
- 缺水：另一实验发现，有些柳树因河床被冲得更深，根已够不到水；即便减少鹿啃食，也未必能重新长好。
- 争议：2025年仍有研究认为狼的连锁作用很强，也有人质疑方法。狼究竟帮助恢复了多少植被，仍须证据，不能只凭一个好听的故事。